

Husbands, Love Your Wives

As Yahshua Loves His Bride

A Midrash Study on Ephesians 5:22-33

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible with the sacred names restored. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Paul does not end Ephesians 5 on marriage advice. He ends it by calling marriage a great mystery that speaks about Messiah and his assembly.

Marriage was never mainly about companionship. It is a living picture, walking around on the earth, of the covenant between Yahshua and his people. That is why the enemy attacks it so hard. Break the picture, and you distort what people believe about YHWH himself.

SECTION I

The Text

Subjecting yourselves to one another in the fear of Messiah. Wives, be subject to your own husbands, as to Yahshua. For the husband is the head of the wife, as Messiah also is the head of the assembly, being himself the savior of the body.

Husbands, love your wives, even as Messiah also loved the assembly, and gave himself up for it, that he might sanctify it, having cleansed it by the washing of water with the word, that he might present the assembly to himself glorious, not having spot or wrinkle or any such thing, but that it should be holy and without defect.

Even so husbands also ought to love their own wives as their own bodies. He who loves his own wife loves himself. For no man ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, even as Yahshua also does the assembly.

For this cause a man will leave his father and mother and will be joined to his wife. Then the two will become one flesh. This mystery is great, but I speak concerning Messiah and of the assembly.

EPHESIANS 5:21-33

Notice where Paul lands. Everything he just said about a husband and a wife turns out to be a picture of Yahshua and his bride. Read the passage without that ending and it becomes a list of household rules. Read it with that ending and it becomes a revelation of how YHWH loves his people.

SECTION II

The Weight of the Command

Read what Paul actually asks of the husband. He does not say love her as much as you can. He does not say love her the way she loves you. He does not say love her while she deserves it.

He says: **love her the way Yahshua loved the assembly**. And how did Yahshua love the assembly? He gave himself up for it.

But Elohim commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Messiah died for us.

ROMANS 5:8

That is the standard. He died for a bride who was not yet cleaned up, not yet respectful, not yet grateful. He did not wait for her to become worthy. He made her worthy by loving her first.

We love him, because he first loved us.

1 JOHN 4:19

SAY IT PLAINLY

Husband, you go first. Every time. Not because she earned it. Not because she asked correctly. Because that is what your Head did for you while you were still his enemy.

SECTION III

The Backdrop: YHWH Has Always Been a Husband

Ephesians 5 is not new material. Paul is standing on the whole Tanakh. YHWH has described himself as a husband from the beginning.

Jeremiah 31:32	My covenant they broke, although I was a husband to them, says YHWH.
Isaiah 54:5	For your Maker is your husband. YHWH of Armies is his name.
Isaiah 62:5	As the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so your Elohim will rejoice over you.
Hosea 2:19-20	I will betroth you to me forever, in righteousness, in justice, in loving kindness, and in compassion.
Hosea 2:14	I will allure her, bring her into the wilderness, and speak tenderly to her.
Ezekiel 16:8-14	He covers her nakedness, enters covenant, washes her with water, anoints her with oil, clothes her, adorns her, and makes her beauty perfect.
Song of Solomon 4:7	You are all beautiful, my love. There is no spot in you.
Jeremiah 2:2	I remember for you the kindness of your youth, the love of your weddings.

Jeremiah 3:8

He gives faithless Israel a certificate of divorce for covenant breaking. Covenant is real, and breaking it is real.

Sinai Was a Wedding

Look at Exodus 19 through 24 with wedding eyes:

- YHWH comes down to meet the people. **Exodus 19:11**
- The people wash their garments and set themselves apart for three days, the bridal immersion. **Exodus 19:10, 14**
- He speaks the terms of the covenant, the ketubah, his instructions.
- The people answer, all that YHWH has spoken we will do. That is the bride saying I do. **Exodus 19:8; 24:3, 7**
- The covenant is confirmed with blood, and the elders eat and drink before him, the covenant meal. **Exodus 24:8, 11**

His instructions are not a legal code handed down to slaves. They are the marriage covenant a Husband gave to a bride he had just rescued out of Egypt. That reframes everything. **Obedience is how you love the one you are in covenant with**, not a burden laid on you by a distant judge.

If you love me, keep my commandments.

JOHN 14:15

SECTION IV**The Hebrew Betrothal Pattern**

Yahshua followed the ancient wedding pattern exactly. Every husband should know this, because it shows the shape of covenant love.

1. The price is paid.

You were bought with a price (**1 Corinthians 6:20**). You were redeemed with the precious blood of Messiah (**1 Peter 1:18-19**). The bridegroom paid the mohar to the father before he ever took her home.

2. The covenant is cut over a cup.

This cup is the new covenant in my blood, which is poured out for you (**Luke 22:20**). He lifted the cup, she drank, and they were bound. That is betrothal, and betrothal was already full covenant.

3. He goes to prepare a place.

In my Father's house are many homes. If it weren't so, I would have told you. I am going to prepare a place for you. If I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will receive you to myself.

JOHN 14:2-3

The groom went home and built onto his father's house. He did not come back until the father said it was finished.

4. No one knows the day or hour.

No one knows of that day and hour, not even the angels of heaven, but the Father only (**Matthew 24:36**). That is not mystery for its own sake. That is the wedding custom: the father decides when the house is ready.

5. He returns with a shout and a trumpet.

- At midnight there was a cry, behold, the bridegroom is coming, come out to meet him. **Matthew 25:6**
- With a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trumpet of Elohim. **1 Thessalonians 4:16**
- He will send out his angels with a great sound of a trumpet, and they will gather together his chosen ones. **Matthew 24:31**

6. The wedding supper.

Let us rejoice and be exceedingly glad, for the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready (**Revelation 19:7-9**). She comes down prepared as a bride adorned for her husband (**Revelation 21:2**).

Paul saw himself standing inside this pattern as the friend of the bridegroom: I betrothed you to one husband, that I might present you as a pure virgin to Messiah (**2 Corinthians 11:2**). John said the same, the friend of the bridegroom rejoices greatly because of the bridegroom's voice (**John 3:29**).

APPLY IT

You are in a betrothal, not a transaction. You did not buy her the way Yahshua bought you, but you are still called to spend yourself on her the same way: pay first, prepare a place, and keep the covenant while you wait.

SECTION V

The Five Verbs: How Yahshua Loves

This is the spine of the whole study. Paul does not leave *love her like Messiah* undefined. He gives five specific actions in Ephesians 5:25-29.

1. He GAVE HIMSELF UP

Ephesians 5:25

The first move of headship is death, not leadership.

- Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends. **John 15:13**
- The Son of Man came not to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many. **Matthew 20:28**
- He emptied himself, taking the form of a servant, and humbled himself, becoming obedient to the point of death. **Philippians 2:5-8**

Most husbands are willing to die for their wives in theory. Take a bullet. Run into a burning house. Very few are willing to die daily in the small places: die to being right, die to the last word, die to the evening you had planned, die to the hobby, die to the phone, die to your own comfort. **Yahshua did not only die for her. He lived giving himself up for her, every single day, until the day he did it publicly.**

2. He SANCTIFIES her, he sets her apart

Ephesians 5:26

To sanctify is to set apart for one purpose only. He does not share her. He does not compare her. He does not put her in a lineup.

Practically, she is set apart from every other woman in your life: from the ones on the screen, from the one at work who laughs at your jokes, from your mother's expectations, from your past. Set apart also means set above your calling, your business, and even your ministry.

- You shall not covet your neighbor's wife. **Exodus 20:17**
- Let your fountain be blessed, and rejoice in the wife of your youth. **Proverbs 5:18**
- I made a covenant with my eyes. How then should I look lustfully at a young woman. **Job 31:1**

3. He CLEANSSES her with the washing of water with the word

Ephesians 5:26

This is the bridal immersion. It is Ezekiel 16:9 all over again: then I washed you with water. The husband is the one who washes his wife with the word.

A WARNING TO HUSBANDS

Washing is gentle. Washing removes what is not hers. Washing is something you do kneeling down, for the good of the one you are caring for.

The word in your hand is **a basin of water for her, not a club to correct her with**. If she flinches when you open Scripture, you have turned the washing into a beating.

What washing actually looks like:

- Praying over her out loud, by name, in her hearing.
- Speaking Scripture over her identity, not over her failures.
- Covering her in prayer before she ever asks you to.
- Reminding her what YHWH says about her on the day she has forgotten.

Sanctify them in your truth. Your word is truth (**John 17:17**).

4. He PRESENTS her glorious, without spot or wrinkle

Ephesians 5:27

Yahshua does not look at his bride and see her current condition. He sees the finished woman he is going to present.

He called Simon a rock while Simon was still unstable enough to deny him three times (**John 1:42; Matthew 16:18**). He called Gideon a mighty man of valor while Gideon was hiding in a winepress from the Midianites (**Judges 6:12**).

ASK YOURSELF

Do you speak to your wife's condition, or to her calling?

Your words are prophetic in your home. She will very often grow into whatever you keep calling her, for good or for evil. Death and life are in the power of the tongue (**Proverbs 18:21**).

5. He NOURISHES and CHERISHES her

Ephesians 5:29

These are present tense, ongoing words. The stake was once. The nourishing and cherishing is every day.

- **Nourish** means to feed, to provide, to cause to grow: spiritually, emotionally, and physically.
- **Cherish** means literally to warm with body heat, the way a bird covers her young.

Provision without warmth is not this command. A man can pay every bill in the house and never once cherish his wife. **Cold provision is not love. It is management.**

You husbands, in the same way, live with your wives according to knowledge, giving honor to the woman as to the weaker vessel, as also being joint heirs of the grace of life, that your prayers may not be hindered.

1 PETER 3:7

SECTION VI

Headship Redefined

*For the husband is the head of the wife, as Messiah also is the head of the assembly, **being himself the savior of the body.***

EPHESIANS 5:23

Paul defines headship in the same breath he states it: savior of the body. Head means the one who goes first into the danger, not the one who sits highest at the table. And Yahshua drew the line himself.

You know that the rulers of the nations lord it over them, and their great ones exercise authority over them. It shall not be so among you, but whoever desires to become great among you shall be your servant.

MATTHEW 20:25-27

Every worldly definition of headship is exactly what Yahshua forbade. If your leadership looks like the rulers of the nations, issuing orders, demanding compliance, keeping score, then you are not leading like the Head. You are leading like Babylon.

Notice also the verse that governs the entire passage, the one sitting right before it begins: subjecting yourselves to one another in the fear of Messiah (**Ephesians 5:21**). That is the header over the whole household section. Mutual submission comes first, and everything after it is worked out underneath it.

Headship is also not superiority. Yahshua submits to the Father (**1 Corinthians 11:3; 15:28**) and is fully YHWH. Order of function is never a statement of worth.

SECTION VII

Measured Against His Own Body

Even so husbands also ought to love their own wives as their own bodies. He who loves his own wife loves himself. For no man ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it.

EPHESIANS 5:28-29

This flows straight out of the design. A man will leave his father and his mother, and will join to his wife, and they will be one flesh (**Genesis 2:24**). They are no more two, but one flesh. What therefore Elohim has joined together, let no man tear apart (**Matthew 19:6**).

If you are one flesh, then every cutting word you speak to her is **self harm**. You would not starve your own arm. You would not mock your own leg in front of your friends. You would not ignore an infection in your own hand for years and call it her problem. The wound you leave in her is a wound in you. That is not poetry. That is the mechanics of one flesh.

The Side of Adam and the Side of Yahshua

YHWH Elohim caused a deep sleep to fall on the man, and he slept. He took one of his ribs, and made a woman, and brought her to the man.

GENESIS 2:21-22

One of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and immediately blood and water came out.

JOHN 19:34

Adam fell into a deep sleep, his side was opened, and out of the wound came his bride. Yahshua fell into the sleep of death, his side was opened, and out came blood and water: the blood that redeems her, and the water that washes her, exactly as Ephesians 5:26 says.

THE PICTURE

The bride comes out of the opened side of the man. She was never taken from his foot to be walked on, and never from his head to rule over him. **She came from his side, from under his arm, close to his heart.**

SECTION VIII

Examples: How Yahshua Actually Treated People

Paul says to love her as Messiah loved. So let us look at what he actually did. Every one of these is a direct pattern for a husband.

1. He washed feet.

John 13:1-17

Having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end. Knowing all authority was in his hands, he got up, took a towel, and washed dirt off feet, including the feet of the man about to betray him.

Husband: What is the towel in your house? What is the job nobody sees?

2. He served before he was thanked.

Luke 17:11-19

He healed ten lepers. One came back. He healed them anyway.

Husband: Love that requires a thank you is a transaction.

3. He knew her whole history and did not shame her.**John 4:1-29**

The woman at the well had five husbands and was living with a man. He named the truth without weaponizing it, gave her living water, and made her the first witness to her city.

Husband: Knowing her failures is not permission to bring them up.

4. He stood between her and the accusers.**John 8:1-11**

He put his own body between a guilty woman and the stones. Then he said, neither do I condemn you, go your way, from now on sin no more.

Husband: Do you stand between your wife and the accusation, including your own tongue?

5. He prayed for Peter before Peter failed.**Luke 22:31-32**

I prayed for you, that your faith would not fail. He interceded before the fall instead of condemning after it.

Husband: Are you praying about her weak place, or complaining about it?

6. He wept with them before he fixed anything.**John 11:32-35**

He was about to raise Lazarus in ten minutes. He wept first.

Husband: She usually does not want the solution yet. She wants you in the grief with her first.

7. He would not break what was already bent.**Isaiah 42:3; Matthew 12:20**

He will not break a bruised reed. He will not quench a smoking wick.

Husband: When she is already at her weakest, that is the moment to be gentlest, not the moment to make your point.

8. He did not quarrel or raise his voice in the street.**Isaiah 42:2; Matthew 12:19**

He did not strive, nor cry out, and no one heard his voice in the streets.

Husband: Volume is not authority. A raised voice in a marriage is a confession that you have run out of self control.

9. He forgave while he was still being wronged.**Luke 23:34**

Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing. The nails were still in his hands.

Husband: He did not wait for an apology, and neither can you.

10. He restored the one who failed him publicly.**John 21:9-17**

Peter denied him three times. Yahshua cooked him breakfast on a beach and asked, do you love me, three times. One restoration for every denial.

Husband: Full restoration, not probation. Not held over her head for years.

11. He carried her burden instead of adding to it.**Matthew 11:28-30**

Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened. My yoke is easy and my burden is light.

Husband: Is your house a place she can rest, or one more place she has to perform?

12. He honored the woman the room called wasteful.**Mark 14:3-9**

When they criticized the woman with the alabaster jar, he defended her out loud. Leave her alone. Why do you trouble her?

Husband: Defend her in the room, correct in private. Never the other way around.

SECTION IX

The Husband's Instructions Across Scripture

Exodus 21:10

Even a man who took a second wife could not diminish the first wife's food, clothing, or marital rights. YHWH set a floor under how a woman is to be treated. **Provision, covering, and intimacy are her right, not her reward.**

Deuteronomy 24:5

A newly married man goes to no war and carries no business obligation for one full year, and shall cheer his wife whom he has taken. The Creator built a protected year of undistracted attention into his instructions. If he guarded the first year like that, what do you suppose he thinks of a man who gives his wife his leftovers for thirty years?

Malachi 2:13-16 and 1 Peter 3:7

The men in Malachi were weeping at the altar because YHWH would not accept their offerings. Why? YHWH has been witness between you and the wife of your youth, against whom you have dealt treacherously, though she is your companion and the wife of your covenant. **Their worship was rejected because of how they treated their wives.**

Peter says the same thing on the other side of the resurrection: live with her according to knowledge, give her honor, remember she is a joint heir of the grace of life, that your prayers may not be hindered.

TWO WITNESSES

Two witnesses, one on each side of the stake, saying the same thing: **how you treat your wife directly affects your standing in prayer and worship.**

You cannot be right with YHWH and wrong with her. There is no such thing as a powerful man of prayer who is a tyrant at home. That man is deceiving himself.

- **Colossians 3:19.** Husbands, love your wives, and do not be bitter against them. Bitterness is named as the husband's specific sin. It is what unforgiveness becomes when it is allowed to sit.
- **1 Corinthians 7:3-5.** Mutual authority, mutual obligation, and no withholding from one another except by agreement for a season of prayer.

- **Proverbs 5:18-19.** Rejoice, delight, and be captivated by the wife of your youth. Delight is commanded, not optional.
- **Proverbs 31:28-29.** Her husband also praises her. Out loud, where people can hear it.
- **1 Corinthians 13:4-8.** Read it with her name in mind. Patient, kind, not jealous, not proud, not rude, not self seeking, not provoked, keeps no record of wrongs, bears all things, never fails.

SECTION X

Where It Actually Breaks: Pride and Forgiveness

Here is the honest part, and it is the heart of everything we teach at Kingdom Life.

Almost no marriage dies from one big event. Marriages die from **a stack of unforgiven small things**: offenses filed away, kept on a list, pulled back out in every argument, held as leverage.

And unforgiveness is never the root. **Pride is the root.** Unforgiveness is what pride looks like when it is wearing a wound as a costume.

Pride says: what she did was too big, I have a right to hold this, she has to come to me first, I have to protect myself. Pride is sneaky. It will disguise itself as boundaries, as discernment, as being the spiritual one in the house, as I have forgiven her, I just do not trust her. It will let a man sit in bitterness for a decade and call it wisdom.

THE ORDER OF THINGS

Humility is the root of forgiveness. Forgiveness is the root of deliverance.

If you want deliverance in your house, it starts with you forgiving her completely, out loud, without conditions, and then humbling yourself enough to ask her forgiveness for what you have done. Not a general apology. Specific. That is where chains break.

- If you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses. **Matthew 6:14-15**
- Be kind to one another, tender hearted, forgiving each other, just as Elohim also in Messiah forgave you. **Ephesians 4:32**
- Forgiving each other, if any man has a complaint against any, even as Messiah forgave you, so you also do. **Colossians 3:13**
- Elohim resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble. **James 4:6**
- Do not let the sun go down on your wrath, and do not give place to the devil. **Ephesians 4:26-27**

That last one is a warning about legal ground. Anger held overnight, night after night, becomes an open door. Many men are fighting torment in their own homes that they themselves let in through years of unforgiveness toward the woman sleeping next to them.

SECTION XI

What This Does Not Mean

Truth in love means saying this part plainly.

- **Headship is not control.** Yahshua never once forced his bride. He invites, he serves, he waits. A man who uses Ephesians 5 to demand compliance has inverted the passage. Paul gave the wife one verse and the husband nine.
- **Submission is not obedience to sin or to abuse.** As to Yahshua, in verse 22, is a limit, not a blank check. Nothing in Scripture requires a woman to submit to being harmed. A man who is harming his wife has already broken the covenant he is appealing to.
- **Her submission is not the condition of your love.** Verse 25 has no if in it. Messiah loved her while she was still a sinner, and you are not permitted to wait.
- **Loving her is not weakness.** It took more strength for Yahshua to stay on the stake than it would have taken to call twelve legions of angels (**Matthew 26:53**). Restraint under provocation is the strongest thing a man does.
- **This is not about being perfect.** It is about direction. Repenting and returning, over and over, is the walk.

SECTION XII

Walking It Out This Week

Practical, testable, and small enough to actually do. Seven days.

- 1 Wash her once a day.** Pray over her out loud, by name, in her hearing. Not about her. Over her.
- 2 Take the towel.** Do one thing she normally does, without being asked, and without mentioning it afterward.
- 3 Name her calling, not her condition.** Tell her one true thing about who she is becoming.
- 4 Forgive one specific thing.** Say it to YHWH out loud, release it, and then never bring it up again. Not in an argument, not as a joke.
- 5 Ask her forgiveness for one specific thing.** No but. No if I. Name it and ask.
- 6 Cherish, do not just provide.** Warmth costs time, not money. Sit with her with nothing in your hands.
- 7 Defend her in the room.** Publicly, once, where she can hear it.

Cross Reference Index

Love defined: 1 Corinthians 13:4-8

Personal Notes and Convictions

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.